

Set SMART Goals

Third, your goals need to be SMART goals. This is an acronym authors and teachers have used for decades to teach people how to set good, well-thought-out goals. For your goals to be SMART, they need to be:

- *Specific*: Leave no room for ambiguity. Write out exactly what you want to accomplish in detail. This is where your high-definition retirement dream comes into play.
- *Measurable*: How will you know if you achieved your goals? Use specific facts, milestones, and metrics so you'll know for sure if you're hitting your goals or not.
- *Achievable*: Be realistic with your goals. Sure, we all want to be billionaires, but that's unlikely for most people. Hitting millionaire status, though, is totally achievable. I want you to dream big, but not so big that you'll never be able to accomplish your goals.
- *Relevant*: Your goals need to be focused. They need to take you closer to where you ultimately want to end up. Having a few random goals here and there is fine for variety, but your big goals need to work together to bring you into the life you've envisioned for yourself.
- *Time-Sensitive*: Every goal needs a deadline. Challenge yourself to get the job done by a specific date. In retirement planning, for example, this could be the age when you want to retire. And don't be scared to make the timeline ambitious. You'll be amazed how efficiently you can work toward your goals when you know you have a deadline coming up.

Now, let's see what this looks like in practice. Assume you want to pay off your mortgage early. You wouldn't simply write, "I want to pay my house off early" and leave it at that. That goal isn't SMART; it's dumb! It's